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Renault recommends Castrol

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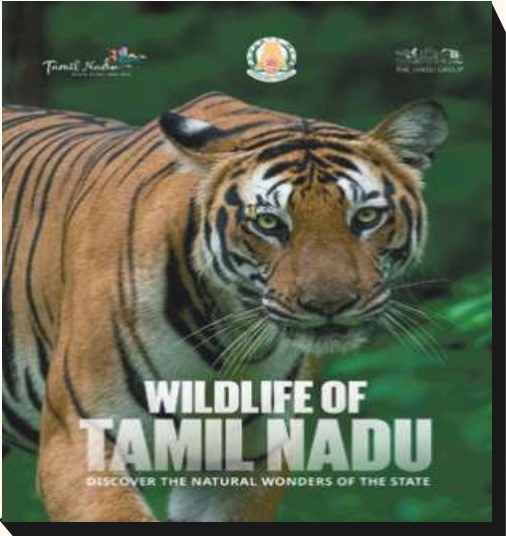
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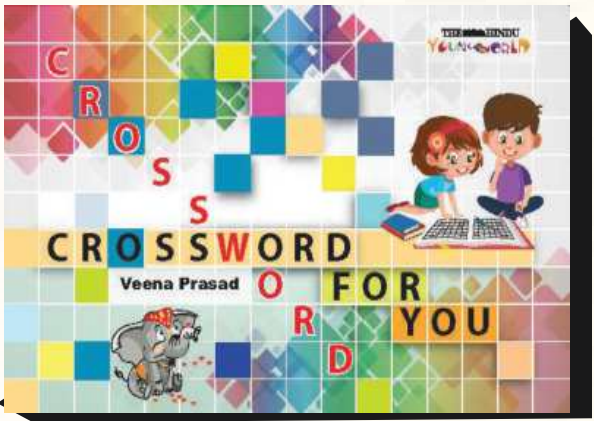
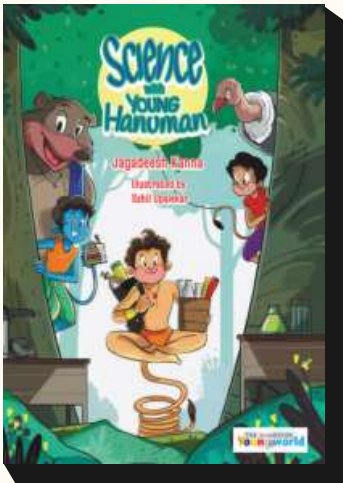
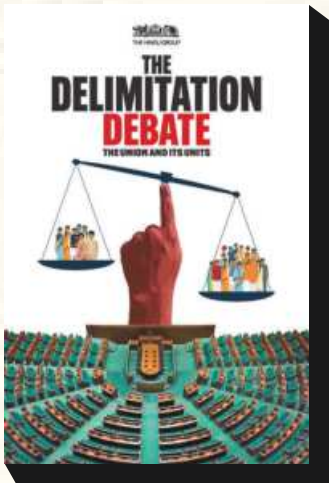
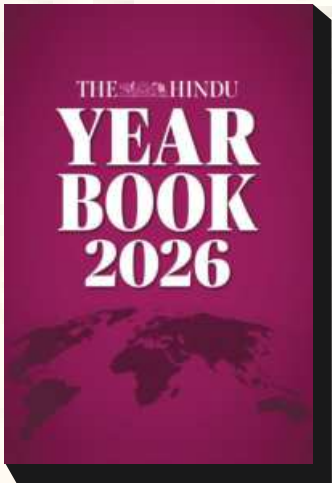
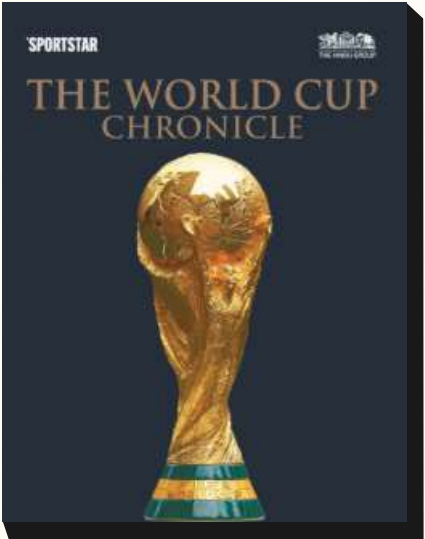
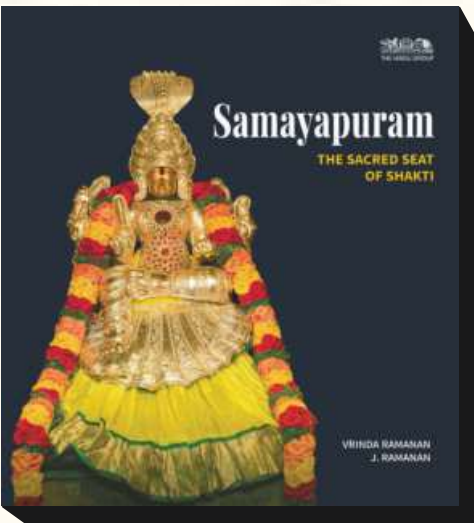
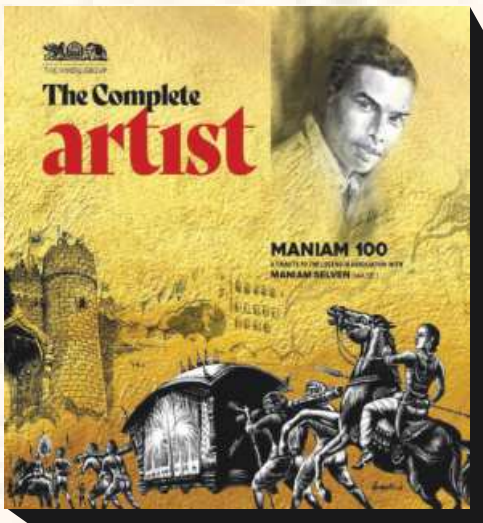
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QUICKLY.

SC to hear plea on MDR on UPI above ₹2,000 today



New Delhi: The Supreme Court will on Monday hear a plea challenging the Centre's decision to impose a merchant discount rate (MDR) on specified UPI person-to-merchant transactions of over ₹2,000. Ending nearly six years of fully free UPI payments, the government has introduced a 0.4 per cent fee on transfers worth over ₹2,000 made to merchants through the UPI platform from October 15 while explicitly ring-fencing everyday person-to-person transactions and small payments from any charge. According to the apex court's cause list of September 28, the plea would come up for hearing before a bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana. **■**

TODAY'S PICK.

Manappuram Finance (₹334): **BUY**

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The stock of Manappuram Finance saw a decline in price in the recent weeks. However, the long-term trend remains bullish. Since June 2022, such price corrections were followed by a fresh leg of rally. A sharp rebound in the second half of last week indicates that the scrip has resumed the rally after temporary fall in price. We expect the stock to surpass the resistance at ₹375 and touch ₹400 over the medium-term. Therefore, traders can buy the stock now at ₹334 and

Manappuram Finance
Return 18% ₹ 334

accumulate if the price declines to ₹320. Place initial stop-loss at ₹295. When the stock appreciates to ₹365, revise the stop-loss to ₹335. Tighten the stop-loss further to ₹370 when the price touches ₹385. Book profits at ₹400.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading.

GST Council may approve freight movement through metro trains

DIGITAL PUSH. E-way bills may soon be generated for goods moved via the network; crucial meeting on Oct 7

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

E-way bills could soon be generated for goods transported through metro rail network as the GST Council is likely to consider a proposal to include the metro rail in the modes of transport.

The Council is also expected to take up a proposal to clear the ambiguity on permanent transfer of Intellectual Property Right (IPR) for GST levy.

The Council is scheduled to meet on October 7. The Law Committee of the Council has already given recommendations on both the proposals among a number of other proposals.

As on date, GST rules say goods transported by railways or by air or vessels val-



CLEARING THE AIR. The Council to take up a proposal to clear the ambiguity on permanent transfer of IPR for GST levy

ued above a certain threshold need to have e-way bill. Though the expression 'railways' has not been defined in the GST rules, metro rail systems including DMRC (Delhi Metro Rail Corporation) are legally distinct from Indian Railways.

KEY REASON
According to officials, this is one key reason to include the term metro rail in the rule to overcome operational diffi-

culty by DMRC. "DMRC has planned to initiate a pilot depot-to-depot cargo movement through urban freight services, utilising the metro network as middle-mile connectivity. E-way bill portal is designed specifically for Indian Railways and does not adequately cater to the movement of goods through a metro rail system, resulting in operational difficulties," an official explained, adding that metro in other cities could also benefit from the move.

India's Metro rail network has reached around 1,170 km across 26 cities and could surpass the US within the next two years. India now stands just 216 km behind the US, which has a Metro rail network of around 1,386 km. China remains far ahead with an urban rail network of nearly 8,000 km.

An e-way bill is an electronic document generated on a portal, evidencing the movement of goods. It also indicates whether tax has been paid for the moving goods.

As per Rule 138 of the CGST Rules, 2017, every registered person involved in the movement of goods (which may not necessarily be on account of supply) of consignment value of more than ₹50,000 (can be lower for intra-state movement) is required to generate an e-way bill.

IPR TRANSFER
Presently, permanent transfer of IPR is notified as taxable both as a supply of goods and as a supply of services and no distinct tariff item or heading has been created for such intangible goods, resulting the classification ambiguity. "In order to ensure that is unambiguously payable on every transfer of IPR, whether, temporary or permanent, the Law Committee has recommended both to be treated at supply of services," the official said.

According to him, such a classification would provide a practical mechanism for payment of tax on cross border supply of IPR from outside India to India as import of services.

Govt directs company-run power plants to supply surplus electricity in market

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The government has directed captive power plants to maximise generation and supply surplus electricity for sale through exchanges in anticipation of rising consumption during the high demand October-December period.

India's captive power plants — units owned and operated by companies for self-consumption — had an installed capacity of almost 81 gigawatts (GW) as of FY24 with coal accounting for a major share (around 46 GW), diesel (19.6 GW), gas (6.2 GW), wind (3.4 GW) and solar (4.5 GW).

"Considering the prevailing demand-supply scenario and the expected rise in electricity demand in the coming months, the Ministry of Power is undertaking various measures to ensure adequate supply of electricity to consumers," the Ministry said in an order.

OPTIMISE AVAILABILITY
To ensure optimal availability of power to the consumers, the Ministry invoked Section 11 of the Electricity Act, 2003, directing captive coal-based gener-

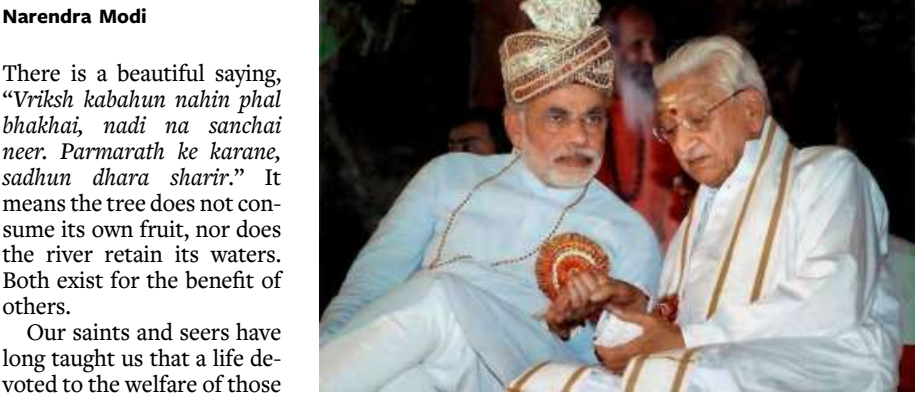
ating stations of the installed capacity of 50 megawatt (MW) and above, shall operate and generate power to the maximum extent of their available capacity.

"The generators shall offer their available surplus generation, after meeting their own captive demand, through the power exchanges, in accordance with the applicable market regulations and procedures," it has directed captive power generators.

The generators shall maintain adequate coal stock so as to ensure availability of fuel for operation of the plant and enable maximum generation. Besides, they will also submit a weekly report to the Central Electricity Authority indicating generation, captive consumption and sale of power through the power exchanges or other permitted avenues, along with details of available capacity and coastock, as may be prescribed.

"The above directions shall be applicable for the period from October 1, 2026 till December 31, 2026, taking into account the prevailing power demand-supply position and the requirement for ensuring adequate availability of power in the grid," the order said.

A great personality, committed to nation-building



Ashok Singhal with Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Narendra Modi

There is a beautiful saying, "Vriksh kabahum nahin phal bhakhai, nadi na sanchai neer. Parmarath ke karane, sadhun dhara sharir." It means the tree does not consume its own fruit, nor does the river retain its waters. Both exist for the benefit of others.

Our saints and seers have long taught us that a life devoted to the welfare of those around us acquires a meaning far greater than individual achievement. If there is one person in whom this spirit was constantly reflected, it was Shri Ashok Singhal *ji*.

Starting 27 September, we mark his birth centenary to celebrate an outstanding personality who brought together spiritual pursuit, cultural awakening and decades of dedicated organisational work.

I consider it a privilege that I had innumerable opportunities to interact with Ashok *ji*. One of the earliest instances dates back to 1981. I received a handwritten letter from him. It was a noteworthy moment for me. He talked about an important upcoming programme and gave a few tasks.

DIFFICULT TRAVELS
Over several decades, I saw him work day and night. He would undertake long and often difficult travels to the remotest of areas. He was particularly passionate about travelling across tribal areas of Gujarat. His mind was constantly thinking about what more one can do for those on the margins of society.

Whenever any part of the nation was affected by a natural disaster, Ashok *ji* was

either among the first to reach there himself or among those guiding *karyakartas* to help those affected. My own experience with him in the aftermath of the 2001 Kutch earthquake was unforgettable.

This spirit of compassion and care for others is something that came to Ashok *ji* very early in his life. He hailed from a very illustrious and prosperous family. His father, Shri Mahavir *ji*, was a distinguished administrator.

One of his brothers, Shri BP Singhal *ji*, went on to become a police officer and later a Member of Parliament. Another brother, Shri VP Singhal *ji*, was the Chief Secretary of Tripura when the state was just formed. Other family members succeeded in the world of commerce and agriculture. But from a young age, Ashok *ji* was attracted to something else altogether... the revival of Bharat and bringing glory to *Maa Bharti's* children.

CULTURAL ETHOS
Growing up in Prayagraj, Ashok *ji* would sit for hours on the banks of the *Sangam*. The river naturally interested him, but so did the people who came, such as saints, seers and devotees. It nurtured an understanding of India's cultural ethos and strengthened his intention to do something for society. This desire to live for others drew him to the RSS. He embraced every responsibility that came his way with enthusiasm, discipline and a sense of duty.

Ashok *ji* nurtured institutions and movements

Ashok *ji* at the peak of the movement.

Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible. He would have been the happiest person on seeing the Ram Mandir take shape in Ayodhya.

Ashok *ji* was blessed with remarkable clarity of thought and one area where it was clearly seen was his belief that our society needs to be harmonious. He worked towards strengthening social unity and equality.

He firmly believed that there could be no distinction of any kind in society and that every individual deserved equal respect. It was his thought that the first brick of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya would be laid by Shri Kameshwar Choupal *ji*, a grassroots VHP *karyakarta* from Bihar who hailed from the marginalised sections of society. At a Dharm Sansad in Kashi, he decided that the Dom Raja would be honoured and went on to work with him as part of various community efforts. Beyond nation-building, Ashok *ji* had two areas that were very close to his heart: education (especially Vedic education) and music. As the MP from Varanasi, I feel very proud that the city I represent, the eternal Kashi, has played its part in Ashok *ji's* life.

BASIC EDUCATION
He was educated at BHU and was known to be a good student. He was closely associated with the Ekal Vidyalaya initiative, which worked to extend basic education to remote villages and tribal communities.

He was a voracious reader as well as a good listener and he always told younger *karyakartas* to read as much as possible.

On his birth centenary, let us ensure that more youngsters know about his greatness. And let us renew our pledge to realise his dreams for our nation and our people.

The writer is the Prime Minister of India

Enterprise Connect

Bank of Baroda Unveils AI-Powered bob World 2.0 for Smarter Digital Banking

Bank of Baroda has launched bob World 2.0, its next-generation mobile banking platform powered by Artificial Intelligence (AI), marking a significant milestone in the bank's digital transformation journey. The new application was showcased at the Global Fintech Fest 2026 in Mumbai in the presence of senior officials from the Department of Financial Services and Bank of Baroda's leadership team. Built on a modern microservices-based digital architecture, bob World 2.0 is designed to provide customers with a seamless, intelligent and secure banking experience. The platform introduces advanced features such as Conversational Banking, allowing users to perform transactions and navigate services through voice commands, and a comprehensive Personal Financial Management (PFM) module that helps customers track finances and improve financial wellness. The application also offers hyper-personalised banking experiences, catering to specific customer segments including senior citizens, women, NRIs and millennials. Strengthening customer protection, the platform incorporates a robust multi-layered security framework with real-time safeguards against digital threats. Speaking on the launch, Bank of Baroda Managing Director & CEO Dr. Debadatta Chand said the bank remains committed to delivering intuitive, secure and customer-centric digital banking solutions. With bob World 2.0, the bank aims to create a future-ready omni-channel ecosystem that will continue evolving to meet changing customer expectations and enhance overall banking convenience.

Goa Shipyard Achieves Record Financial and Operational Performance in FY 2025-26



Goa Shipyard Limited (GSL) reported an exceptional performance during FY 2025-26 at its 60th Annual General Meeting held on 25 September 2026 under the chairmanship of CMD Shri Brajesh Kumar Upadhyay. The company recorded its best-ever financial results, with Revenue from Operations rising 32% to ₹ 3,764 crore, while Total Revenue crossed the ₹ 4,000 crore mark, reaching ₹ 4,004 crore. EBITDA increased to ₹522 crore and Profit Before Tax grew 17% to ₹442 crore, while Net Worth touched an all-time high of ₹1,936 crore. A major milestone during the year was GSL's elevation from Schedule 'B' to Schedule 'A' CPSE status, reflecting its strong growth trajectory. The company also declared a final dividend of ₹8.55 per share and improved Earnings Per Share to ₹28.47. Operationally, GSL maintained strong shipbuilding momentum with significant progress on Indian Navy and Coast Guard projects, including the launch of the first Next Generation Offshore Patrol Vessel (NGOPV) and delivery of multiple patrol vessels. Export business grew by 55% to ₹127 crore, supported by key international projects. With an order book exceeding ₹13,000 crore, expected to rise to ₹32,400 crore, GSL remains well-positioned for sustained growth while advancing the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat.

Business Initiative

JEEVIKA Strengthens Market Linkages for Women Agri-Entrepreneurs and FPCs in Bihar



To strengthen market access and enhance income opportunities for rural women, JEEVIKA, in collaboration with Syngenta Foundation India and the Gates Foundation, organised a workshop on strengthening agri-output market linkages for Agriculture Entrepreneurs (AEs) and Farmer Producer Companies (FPCs) in Bihar. The programme brought together women agri-entrepreneurs, FPC representatives, institutional buyers, exporters, retailers and development partners to explore sustainable business opportunities and better price realisation for agricultural produce. Inaugurating the workshop, JEEVIKA Chief Executive Officer Himanshu Sharma said connecting Agriculture Entrepreneurs and Producer Companies with markets is vital for strengthening Bihar's rural economy and promoting the growth of Lakhpati Didis. He noted that JEEVIKA has a network of more than 70 Producer Companies and over 5,000 women Agriculture Entrepreneurs contributing significantly to livelihoods and income generation across the state. Additional CEO Ananya Singh highlighted that women entrepreneurs are increasingly participating across the agricultural value chain, from production to marketing, and stressed the need for market-driven cultivation and stronger direct linkages with buyers. Discussions focused on aggregation, grading, packaging, logistics, quality standards and value addition for commodities such as paddy, wheat, maize and makhana. The workshop concluded with a roadmap for building long-term partnerships and a more sustainable market ecosystem for farmers and women-led agribusinesses in Bihar.

Bank of Baroda Supports Smart CCTV Surveillance Initiative in Chennai



Reinforcing its commitment to community safety and sustainable urban development, Bank of Baroda's Chennai Zone has extended support for the installation of branded solar-powered smart poles equipped with CCTV surveillance cameras at selected locations in Chennai. The cheque for the project was handed over by T. N. Suresh, General Manager, Bank of Baroda, Chennai Zone, to Prem Anand Sinha, IPS, Additional Director General of Police and Commissioner of Police, Tambaram City, in the presence of A. Thirumalaikumar, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Tambaram Armed Reserve. The initiative aims to strengthen public safety through enhanced CCTV-based monitoring while promoting environmentally sustainable infrastructure through the bank's green initiative, bobearth. Senior officials including V. G. Senthilkumar, Ravipati Sreenivas and Lakshmi Usha participated in the event. Bank of Baroda reiterated its commitment to partnering with government and law-enforcement agencies in building safer, smarter and more connected communities.

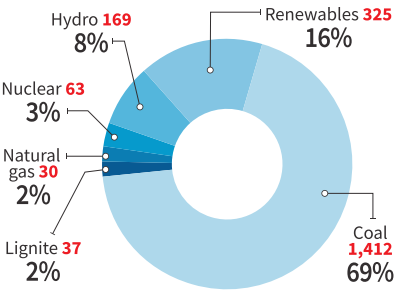
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NEWS SNIPPETS.

Renewable energy meets 55 per cent of annual generation projection

Fuel source for electricity generation programme 2026-27 (MW, %)



Source: Central Electricity Authority, Ministry of Power

India's renewable energy sector generated 177.66 billion kWh (billion units) during April-August 2026, according to the Central Electricity Authority's (CEA) monthly generation data. This is nearly 55 per cent of the 325 billion units of renewable energy generation projected by the CEA for the full year (2026-27) in its Load Generation Balance Report (LGBR).

The CEA has estimated India's total electricity generation for 2026-27 at 2.04 trillion units. If large hydro is included, renewable energy generation during April-August rises to 253.57 billion units. This is 51.4 per cent of the 493 billion units of RE-plus-large hydro generation projected for the full year.

RE, including large hydro, accounted for 28.5 per cent of the country's total generation of 888.53 billion units during the five-month period. This represents about 43.6 per cent of the CEA's projected full-year generation.

The numbers also suggest that renewables, particularly when large hydro is included, are already contributing a larger share of the generation mix than projected for the full year. RE plus large hydro accounted for 28.5 per cent of actual generation during April-August, compared with 24.2 per cent of the generation mix projected for the full year.

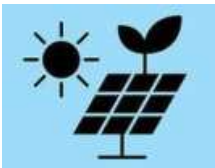
Coal, meanwhile, remains the dominant source of generation. The LGBR projects 1.41 trillion units of coal-based generation for 2026-27—about 69 per cent of the projected total generation.

A notable feature of the CEA data is the sharp rise in large-hydro generation in August. Output increased 16.7 per cent, from 17.75 billion units in July to 20.71 billion units in August, even though installed large-hydro capacity remained unchanged at 52.06 GW.

The increase highlights the seasonal nature of hydro generation: substantial changes in electricity output can occur without any corresponding increase in installed capacity.

CSP could complement large solar parks: NTPC

Concentrated solar power (CSP) plants could provide valuable grid-balancing support alongside large photovoltaic (PV)



installations, and should be considered as part of solar parks, such as the massive renewable energy complex coming up at Khavda, according to Rajan Varshney, DGM, NTPC.

At a conference organised by the Centre for Science and Environment, themed 'National Round-table on Scaling Renewables without Breaking the Grid', at the Anil Agarwal Environment Training Institute in Nimli, Rajasthan, Varshney said CSP's ability to store and deliver solar energy when required could complement the variable output of conventional solar PV.

He also pointed to a less conventional application — supplying high-temperature heat for green hydrogen production.

SHINING SUCCESS

Why India's solar production is a big win

LIGHT AND SHADOW. Pouring investments point to a sector commanding high confidence despite jarring notes from the US

M Ramesh

Solar manufacturing has veritably turned out to be a major success story in India. First, investment in solar manufacturing has risen from \$85 million in 2018 to \$12 billion in calendar 2025 and a further \$4 billion in the first half (H1) of 2026. That is \$16 billion invested in 18 months.

Secondly, the investments announced are a clear pointer too — \$16 billion in 2025 and \$8 billion in H1 2026, according to the 'Clean Investment Monitor' report of the Rhodium Group, a US-based market research and analytics firm specialising in renewable energy.

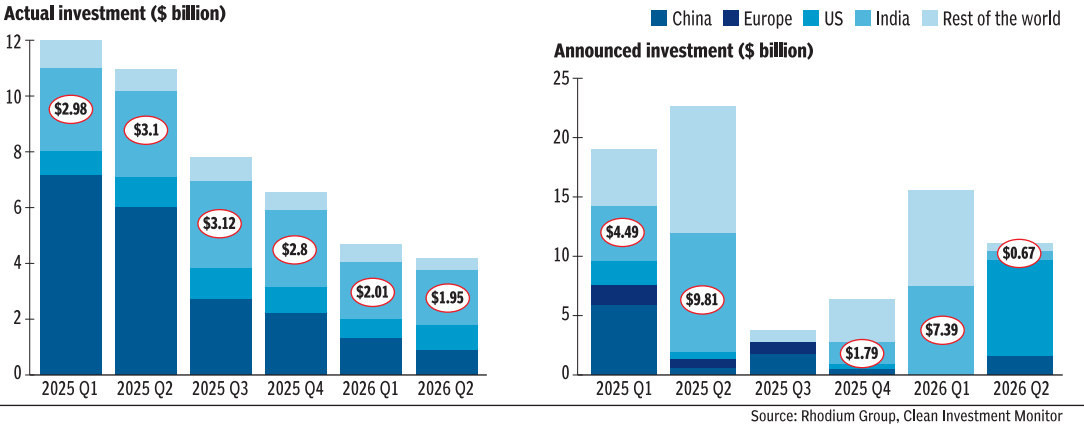
In 2014, India had module manufacturing capacity of about 2.5 GW, and no cells. Today, according to Rhodium, the country has 242.7 GW of module, 40.5 GW of cell and 2.5 GW of wafer capacity. There is a problematic mismatch between module and cell capacity, but since an additional 40 GW of cell capacity is likely to come up (about half of it in 2026), the gap is expected to narrow. Also, 24 GW of wafer capacity has been announced.

It is also clear that the main driver of this growth is the government's mandate to use locally made modules (ALMM-I) and cells through an approved list of models and manufacturers (ALMM), with efforts underway to extend the ALMM to wafers. The scope of this policy has been expanded to cover almost all solar projects in India, except limited exemptions, notably certain net-metering and open-access projects that have been given a commissioning window till December 31.

India's solar installed capacity of about 168 GW today accounts for 12 per cent of its electricity generation.

The jarring note comes in the form of US tariffs. The US is an important export market for some Indian solar manufacturers. That mar-

Solar manufacturing spend continues to fall, but new announcements edge up



STEADY ROLLOUT. India has capacity to make 242.7 GW of solar modules, 40.5 GW of cells and 2.5 GW of wafers

ket is now practically shut by two sets of measures by its government.

One is the recent determination of the US Department of Commerce that India, along with Laos and Indonesia, should face anti-dumping and countervailing duties. For India, the applicable dumping margin is 123.04 per cent, while the final cash-deposit rate for the coun-

tervailing duty, after subsidy offsets, is 107.17 per cent. The US International Trade Commission still has to determine whether the imports have caused material injury to local industry, thereby inviting the duties; else the deposits will be refunded.

The second measure was the imposition of tariffs under Section

232 of the US Trade Expansion Act, giving the US President powers to restrict imports if found to endanger national security. The President has raised two walls — a 15 per cent ad valorem duty on specified polysilicon derivatives; and minimum import prices of \$21 per kg for polysilicon, \$100 per kg for ingots and wafers, \$0.22 per W for

NO OUTAGE

After sunset, BESS is the best option for energy security

M Ramesh

Battery energy storage system is beginning to look like solar did a decade ago — a technology whose importance is moving rapidly from the drawing board to the electricity market. And, increasingly, the market itself is sending the signal.

Government agencies are beginning to adapt the rules to make storage easier to deploy. The latest example is the Central Transmission Utility of India (CTUIL), which last week issued a procedure for BESS projects that have grid connectivity to seek an increase in their energy-storage capacity (MWh) without increasing their approved charging/discharging capacity (MW).

The distinction is significant. A 100 MW/200 MWh battery can, for instance, become a 100 MW/400 MWh battery by adding storage capacity while retaining the same grid connection and power conversion

capacity. CTUIL's move gives developers a regulatory route to do this rather than having to treat the increase in MWh as an increase in grid connectivity.

CTUIL is also seeking clarity from the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission over whether the ₹2 lakh per MW 'Connectivity Bank Guarantee-3' would apply when the increase is only in MWh. Pending clarification, it is not seeking BG-3 for such applications.

But the strongest case for BESS may be coming from the electricity market.

Formerly Grid-India CMD SR Narasimhan recently did a study by modelling the arbitrage potential of a 1 MW BESS using four years of day-ahead market data — 96 time blocks a day, 365 days a year, six storage durations and two operating models. The exercise shows that arbitrage opportunities have generally strengthened, with FY2025-26 emerging as the strongest year for most configurations.

The other finding is equally inter-



POWER ON. Battery energy storage system is a game changer for RE supply

esting: longer-duration batteries earn more, but with diminishing returns. Moving from one hour to six hours of storage gives six times the energy capacity, but arbitrage revenue rises only 3.5-4.4 times. The battery captures the most attractive price spreads first.

And the market is changing with

solar. Cheap charging opportunities are increasingly moving from winter nights to solar-heavy afternoons, while discharge opportunities are emerging around demand peaks, including mornings.

Then there is the ₹20-a-unit signal. Between September 6 and 17, the high price day-ahead market on

solar cells, and \$0.38 per W for modules.

The move could have provided India a foothold in the US market, because it brings everyone onto the same starting line by negating the huge price advantage that China had. But the anti-dumping and countervailing duties slam the door almost completely shut.

Now, there are two questions arising out of this situation: What will be the effect on India, and is there a way Indian manufacturers can still get a slice of the lucrative US market?

The first answer is yes. India's export of modules and cells to the US fetched about \$1.2 billion last year, or 13 per cent of the value of modules and cells produced. These products now have nowhere to turn except the domestic market.

The good news is that the Indian market is large and growing, and there is no reason to presume it cannot absorb the additional supply. Yes, margins may get squeezed, but Indian manufacturers are unlikely to go belly-up.

On whether India still has a chance to take a share of the US market — yes, it does, if Indian companies set up factories in the US. The US welcomes foreign investment in this area. Some Indian companies, like Waaree and Inox, already have a US presence; others like Premier Energies have said they would like to set up plants in the US. That said, there does not appear to be a huge appetite among Indian companies to pitch tent in the US; many manufacturers *businessline* spoke with said it's not an easy step.

There is yet another dimension to this. Indian manufacturers who quickly start producing ingots and wafers have a play in the US market right now, because there is a shortage of non-Chinese wafers there. It could take some time for the US industry to close this gap. Indosol Solar, a subsidiary of Shirdi Sai Electricals, has said its ingot/wafer plant would be commissioned soon and is hopeful of exporting to the US.

How sustainability can sweeten Nagaland's pineapple profits

Study shows that the adoption of progressive practices such as soil healthcare and natural pest control can step up yields and farmers' income

K Bharat Kumar

Farmers, especially in cost-conscious cultures such as India, are good at traditional, cost-free sustainable practices such as weeding, crop spacing, and field hygiene. But they tend to lag in practices such as biological pest control or scientific restoration of soil nutrients that require training and material inputs.

Sustainability clearly isn't just a question of awareness but also tied to land size and income, as seen in a study by the School of Agricultural Sciences, Nagaland University. Published in the *Indian Journal of Extension Education* this year, the study on Nagaland's pineapple growers shows that richer farmers can afford the risk and cost of adopting modern sustainability techniques.

WHY PINEAPPLE

Pineapple is a key crop in the State, covering more than 9,000

hectares, with annual production touching 1,23,300 tonnes in 2023-24. Dimapur district led in output.

Most of the growers rely heavily on traditional practices. The adoption of progressive practices such as crop management, soil healthcare, natural pest control, and scientific post-harvest handling could address a range of problems the growers face, while stepping up yields and income. However, adoption varies greatly among the farmers.

While they handle and store raw pineapples well, very few convert the fruit into processed goods and miss out on higher market profits.

The researchers surveyed 275 growers across 13 villages in three major pineapple producing districts: Dimapur, Peren, and Mokokchung. The study measured adoption across four key areas: practices such as land preparation, varieties, plant spacing, and planting materials; manage-

ment of soil health, water, manuring, irrigation, and weeds; pest and disease management; and post-harvest management, including storage, handling, and value addition.

THE FINDINGS

About 65 per cent of farmers showed a 'medium' level of adoption of sustainable practices. Only 20 per cent showed 'high' adoption, while almost 16 per cent fell into the 'low' adoption category.

All showed a high tendency to adopt basic handling and storage practices. They were also adept at traditional plant propagation and weed management. About 95 per cent used methods such as field sanitation to control pests.

However, there was no adoption of biological pest control across all districts due to lack of awareness, training, and access to commercial bio-control agents. There was no adoption of planting material treatment or



JUICY TID-BIT. Pineapple is a key crop of Nagaland, covering 9,000 ha

plant growth regulators. Only 8 per cent used organic manure and irrigation due to high labour demand, cost, and resource constraints.

Fewer than 18 per cent engage in value addition such as processing pineapples into jam, juice and other products — primarily

due to limited infrastructure and lack of market linkages, the study found.

GOOD PRACTICES

Land use and income were the biggest drivers for the adoption of sustainable agricultural practices. Farmers with larger hold-

ings and higher income are more open to it as they have the financial cushion. Other drivers include direct contact with agricultural extension officers, who connect governments with farmers; participation in training sessions; and access to reliable information.

The study concluded that policy and extension work cannot adopt a 'one-size-fits-all' approach. Prof Kaushal Kumar Jha of NU says, "The challenge is not simply introducing a low-cost processing machine; farmers also need technical skills, institutional support and access to markets." He adds that for village-level deployment, simple, affordable and locally accessible technologies, particularly solar drying and small-scale juice extraction, could be explored.

One practical avenue suggested is a collaboration with the Nagaland Tool Room and Training Centre (NTTC), which has developed technologies such as a

solar fruit and vegetable dryer.

On the low-cost, village-level food processing technologies that can help farmers go up the value chain, Prof Jha points to the solar tunnel dryer, hybrid solar dryer and small-scale milling.

The solar tunnel dryer extends the shelf life of fruits, vegetables, and spices by several months without consuming too much power. It is more hygienic and controllable than open drying under the sun. The cost depends on the size, capacity, and features like hybrid electric backup.

The hybrid solar dryer uses both electricity and the sun, which is useful in areas with frequent power cuts. A vacuum packing machine is used to pack the dried products.

Mini rice mills, flour mills and pulse mills operated at the village level allow farmers to process their own crops. The cost varies according to the capacity of the machines.

OFFICE BUZZ.

Across India, one in three working women is anaemic



One finding stands out in health-tech and wellness platform LivLong 365's Workforce Health Index, derived from a large-scale annual health check-up programme conducted for one of its enterprise clients, screening 10,604 employees across 417 camps in tier 1-4 cities in India between January and March 2026. It finds that 34.7 per cent of the women screened are anaemic, compared to 7.5 per cent of men.

Beyond the numbers, the finding opens up a conversation about how many of the women who manage full-time jobs alongside a disproportionate share of household and caregiving responsibilities tend to deprioritise their own health check-ups.

Skilling in 5G



Ericsson and the Telecom Sector Skill Council have inaugurated a Centre of Excellence (CoE) at Government ITI Govandi, Mumbai, aimed at equipping underserved and aspiring youth with industry-relevant skills in 5G and other emerging technologies.

The training will cover skills in 5G, Internet of Things (IoT), telecom product line assembly, and handheld device repair. Around 300 students are expected to benefit during the first year of the programme, with a focus on employability and job placements.

The initiative is aligned with broader efforts to strengthen India's position as a global manufacturing hub.

Vallari Sanzgiri

Meena (name changed), a resident of Kalpataru in Balkum, Thane, keeps buckets filled at home. Water cuts can last for days, while power outages are a regular summer feature. So when Amazon acquired the plot next to her housing society, the residents welcomed the news. Many expected the tech giant's office to bring higher rentals and improved infrastructure to the area. Instead, they learnt that the site would house a data centre — a large digital storehouse packed with racks and servers — which requires millions of litres of water a day for cooling.

"Last week, we had no water for five days... how will they supply the data centre?" Meena asks *businessline*.

Her question finds an echo far beyond Thane — from Melbourne to Ireland and Italy — as the communities living near data centres push back against the water and power guzzling, the noise, heat and uncertain local benefits. In Melbourne, Jacqui Glover, president of the New Citizens of Tottenham group, says, "Cloud is not invisible. It is made of concrete, steel and relentless noise. Living across the street from it changes your relationship with your own home."

The backlash puts countries such as India in a quandary as they compete for the next wave of investments from hyperscaler companies — Amazon Web Services (AWS), Microsoft Azure, Google Cloud et al. How to build infrastructure for the AI economy without passing the environmental and social costs to host communities?

A typical 100 MW hyperscaler data centre can consume nearly 2 million litres of water per day for on-site cooling, according to the Council on Energy, Environment and Water, or CEEW. This is equivalent to supplying about 15,000 urban residents, as per government estimates. For its next 1 GW AI data centre in India, Google has picked Visakhapatnam, in Andhra Pradesh, a region grappling with "overexploited" groundwater, according to the Central Ground Water Board's 2025 report.

While a conventional data centre meant for general business applications requires 5-15 kW power per hour, an AI data centre with high-performance graphics processing units (GPUs) needs 40-60 kWh, or even 100-plus kWh for cutting-edge AI training facilities — enough to power 1,000 fridges for an hour. Data centres accounted for around 1.5 per cent of global electricity consumption in 2024, with demand projected to double to 945 TWh by 2030, as per a CEEW report.

"Average rack power density is expected to rise from 36 kW per rack in 2023 to 50 kW per rack by 2027, and the economics of AI infrastructure are scaling up at the same pace. Most enterprise data centres were not built for any of this," Rahul Dhar President-Global Datacenter Operations, CtrlS Datacenters, wrote in a company blogpost.

● UNWELCOME NEIGHBOUR

The growing ire against mega data centres

COST OF THE CLOUD. How the AI boom is leaving local communities high and dry



BUILDING RESENTMENT. A 100 MW hyperscaler data centre typically uses 2 million litres of water a day for on-site cooling ISTOCK

Land use for AI data centres is another area of concern, as it entails the clearing and conversion of large tracts, apart from the environmental contamination risks associated with water treatment chemicals, fuel storage and the presence of hazardous materials like lead and mercury in electronic equipment, Sushant Sarin, Managing Director and Head of Commercial Risk Solutions-India, Aon says.

DEMAND FOR TRANSPARENCY

Across the protests globally is the call for regulatory transparency. The WakeUp Thanekar group spearheading the protest against the Amazon data centre in Thane has written to local authorities for details such as the development plan, zoning classification, control regulations and permissions. In Visakhapatnam, project documents are available but there is no clarity on details like the available water source.

While local data centre players confirm the need for environmental clearance due to generator usage, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change said in response to a parliamentary question on data centres, in August, that such projects do not require environmental clearance "per se".

"Then how are they deciding where to situate the data centres? We need to look at the impacts before becoming a hub," Arpitha Kodiveri, comparative environmental law scholar and assistant professor of political science at Vassar College in New York, says.

Lombardy, in Italy, has enforced regional environmental laws to regulate the siting of data centres, including en-

ergy thresholds. For example, structures with 5 MW or less capacity are deemed 'edge' data centres permissible within urban areas, whereas a 10 MW centre would require a territorial agreement, including compensatory measures. Ireland has ruled that data centre companies should generate their own power, 80 per cent on-site renewable.

Most countries regulate data centres by combining fragmented frameworks across cybersecurity, infrastructure development, and land acquisition. India, in 2020, released a draft National Data Centre Policy outlining single-clearance windows, economic zones, renewable energy focus and domestic manufacturing. But since it has not been notified, protests continue to simmer.

Compliance also aids client conversations. Foreign funding for data centres in India cooled from \$600-900 million a month in the first half of 2026 to around \$100 million in the following months, as per Tracxn. Kranthi Bathini, Director of Equity Strategy at WealthMills Securities, attributes this to fears over project delays due to the protests. Interest picked up in September when Swedish private equity firm EQT announced plans to invest around \$30 billion. At the State level, Karnataka recently approved a Sustainable Data Centre Policy to achieve 1 GW capacity by 2031. It proposes a ₹1,300.45 crore revised budget to create 10-12 per cent of India's AI-ready data centre capacity.

OFFICIAL RESPONSE

Responding to the concerns flagged by residents, hyperscalers told *businessline* they are working on sustainable meas-

ures. AWS says its Thane data centre will use a closed-loop chemical coolant instead of water. For power, it will connect to the high-voltage transmission grid through its dedicated industrial substation.

In Visakhapatnam, Google talks of pairing the data centre with a multi-variable response spread over three to five years, including new subsea cable landings, power utility infrastructure, clean energy generation, and a centralised logistics centre.

Recruitment is on to ensure the AI hub is fully staffed for eventual day-one operations, says Alexander Smith, Principal, Global Infrastructure and Energy, Asia Pacific, Google. A "long-term local talent pipeline and local supplier ecosystem" would be established to support multi-decade operations, he adds.

He says independent environment audits are being used to design facilities, including advanced air-cooled systems and sound-damping fans "to ensure we are a quiet, unobtrusive neighbour".

As for power consumption, he points to the company's standard use of 83 per cent less overhead energy than the industry average. It is also investing in clean energy generation in Andhra Pradesh and rest of India.

businessline attempted but received no response from Vizag district officers. Meanwhile, Education, IT and Electronics Minister Nara Lokesh had informed the Legislative Assembly on August 19 that Godavari river water would be diverted through the Polavaram project for the data centre. He added that the targeted 6.5 GW ecosystem for Vizag would require 3 tmc of water annually

(1 tmc is around 28.3 billion litres). The Human Rights Forum points to the discrepancy with the 3.5 tmc cited on August 12 by Chief Minister Chandrababu Naidu.

"It concerns an enormous quantity of water in an already water-stressed Visakhapatnam," it said in a public statement.

REGULATORY HESITANCE

One of the reasons India is keen to enter the data centre market is the potential tax revenue. The government anticipates over \$200 billion tax revenue, contributing to achieving a \$30-trillion economy by 2047, as per Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal.

Between 2019 and 2025, committed investments reached nearly \$95 billion, as per CEEW. A light-touch approach would help maintain this enthusiasm, an industry source argues.

The global call for data sovereignty has also pushed many hyperscalers to invest in long-term contracts to set up local data centres in major markets. Local players worry that the "misguided" and "harmful" dissent will cost India such big-ticket projects. ESDS Software Solutions had even flagged local protests as a risk in its draft red herring prospectus.

Union Minister Jitendra Singh had projected nearly one lakh engineering jobs at an industry meet on 'Future-proofing India's data centres'. Protesters in Vizag counter this with the Google data centre's environment impact assessment report, which mentions just 1,200 jobs, in a marked variance from the reported figure of 1.8 lakh jobs. They question the rationale for offering government subsidies to hyperscaler data centres that offer no domestic benefit.

PATH AHEAD

As of January this year, India hosts around 271 data centres, spread across 23 million sqm, in six metro cities. From 1.5 GW by mid-2025, installed data centre capacity is projected to reach 4.5-6.5 GW by 2030, but still nowhere near the 500 GW capacity in the US and China.

While the country targets 500 GW green energy capacity by 2030, the reliance on State policies remains a crutch. It worsens a widening gap between India's investment-led data centre expansion and a global shift towards performance-based sustainability regulation, as per CEEW. "If data centres consume local power and water without creating broad digital capability, India will have built impressive infrastructure but a poor national bargain," warns Sanchit Vir Gogia, Chief Analyst and founder of Greyhound Research.

Sarin expects the next generation of large AI facilities to favour peripheral or semi-urban locations where grid infrastructure can be developed at scale.

While governments and Big Tech deliberate on the barter, back in Balkum, Meena is left wondering whether there will be enough water and power to secure the basic needs of her family of three, including a toddler.

Inglorious boardrooms

PEOPLE@
WORK


KAMAL KARANTH

When I was younger, most workplace fights ended with a movie or a drink, and we eventually laughed about it. As I got older, every difference of opinion, every increment, every promotion got my colleagues to quit on me. Though we shook hands and parted, some of us have never met since.

I tend to think I will never have a fallout with my co-founder. However, age is a funny thing; my sense is that what brought a younger neighbour, friend, colleague or co-founder together may not necessarily be enough in the face of a major boardroom conflict tomorrow. After all, leaders have to make major decisions, amid two differing sides of emotion. One could rationalise that conflict is like a gym for any leader — you have to be at it to get fitter.

Do strong differences of opinion get compounded with age, when power egos rise? As I hear about boardroom conflicts, notably at Tata Sons, I wonder if an ageing board compounds arguments into fights.

AGEING BOARDS

Most boards are filled with aged men, and not everyone is a wizard like Warren Buffett to deserve to preside till 96. We tend to believe experience serves boards well, and hence global brands have reasonably aged members. It may sound weird to suggest that aged boards create more conflicts, given that these listed companies are the most scrutinised and also financially successful.

Why do boards think they need aged members by their side? A 2023 study on CEO age and firm performance by Florida Atlantic University suggests that older CEOs exhibit significantly lower managerial ability in high-technology firms. While ageing is often associated with greater experience and ability, the research warns it can also lead to a decrease in cognitive function, energy, ambition

Board demographics: Age and gender

Demographic indicators	Last 100 American unicorns	Fortune100	S&P 500	Indian unicorns	NSE100
Average age of board members	46.5-49.5	63.0-64	63.6-63.8	41.5-44 (unlisted); 52.4-55 (pre-IPO)	58.5-59.2
Average number of board members	5.5-7.2	11.5-13	10.7	3.5-5 (unlisted); 7-10 (pre-IPO)	10.52
Share of directors aged less than 50	>60%	1-6%	6-6.3%	75-95% (unlisted); 30-38% (pre-IPO)	3.39% (independent); 10-13.89% (overall)
Share of directors aged more than 66	2%	22-25%	19-21%	<2% (unlisted); 4-6% (pre-IPO)	18-21%
Share of independent directors	12-22%	85-88%	86%	0-15% (unlisted); 50-60% (pre-IPO)	52-55%
Share of female board members	11-15%	34-35%	35%	5-11% (unlisted); 22-26% (pre-IPO)	20.4%-21%
All-male board prevalence	40-43%	0	0	58% (unlisted); <5% (pre-IPO)	0

Source: Xpheno

and, hence, managerial ability.

Should we bet on youth to lead enterprises? The founder-led executive suite in top Indian unicorns averages 34-38 years, backed by an external supervisory board in the 55-64 age bracket, balancing execution agility with governance. However, the young guns aren't making a case for themselves. The startup world's mortality rate is high, and the prominent reason seems to be co-founder conflict. In his book *The Founder's Dilemma*, Harvard Business School professor Noam Wasserman claims that 65 per cent of high-potential startups fail due to conflict among co-founders. CB Insights, a market intelligence platform, lists 'disharmony in teams' among the top 10 reasons for startup failures. The argument that younger leaders will have fewer fights doesn't hold either!

SOCIO SELECTIVITY THEORY

Laura Carstensen, a Stanford psychologist, developed a lifespan theory of motivation — called Socioemotional Selectivity Theory (SST) — which posits that people change goals and priorities based on how much time they have left in life. When people perceive future time horizons as shorter, they prioritise emotionally meaningful goals by savouring the present, investing in sure things, and deepening close relationships rather than seeking new con-

nections. This shift in goals impacts values, preferences, and decision-making. According to SST, older adults prefer to interact with emotionally close partners rather than peripheral social partners, even dropping the latter to increase the emotional density of their social networks. I wonder whether SST can give a new dimension to the ongoing tussle at the Tata board. Some want to hold on to what is sure, and some are looking at a new dawn.

BOARD SELECTION

Appointing a diverse board has been in vogue for a while now. Fortune 100 and S&P 500 companies now have about 34 per cent female representation. However, 40 per cent of the last 100 American unicorns still have 100 per cent all-male board composition.

Most board appointees are known to be based on the CEO's or promoters' preferences; hence, conflict is less likely. Differences of opinion are a healthy sign that board members are questioning what's unbecoming of that institution. The Tata example, though, is an outlier to healthy conflict. Should we say consensus is an enemy to a competent leadership team? We want neither boards that only produce consensus nor fatal conflicts.

Kamal Karanth is co-founder of Xpheno, a specialist staffing firm

● TABLE TALK

From spice extracts to a \$1-billion goal

Chitra Narayanan
V Sajeew Kumar

As you walk into the lobby of the picturesque Ramada resort overlooking the scenic Vembanad lake in Kumbalam, on the outskirts of Ernakulam, a huge screen catches your eye. A video plays on loop, showing the inauguration of a pickleball court, with spice oleoresin and essential oils exporter Synthite Industries' executive chairman and managing director Viju Jacob doing the honours in a sporty T-shirt. Even as we watch the video, the man on the screen arrives to greet us. He is a bustling, energetic presence — he tells us he has been showing the hotel (owned by Synthite) to an architect for expansion ideas. We are ushered into a coffee lounge in the lobby where Jacob excitedly outlines all the plans he has for the new pickleball and padel courts at the Ramada.

"Every Saturday, Sunday we will have a training programme for schoolchildren to play at the pickleball court for ₹200 an hour. Normally the fee is ₹800 per hour... we are providing the children coaching too," he says. Adjacent to the state-of-the-art courts is the renovated Riviera Gardens (a sister property of Ramada), which Jacob tells us is being pitched as a budget-friendly staycation destination with a pickleball package thrown in.

The Synthite factory is at Kolenchery, about 25 km from Ernakulam, but Jacob often holds his business meetings at the Ramada. He now plans to expand his hospitality interests with a property in Munnar. "It is under discussion and similar opportunities are being evaluated," he says.

Tea and coffee are ordered



PICKLES AND PICKLEBALL. Viju Jacob, Executive Chairman and Managing Director, Synthite Industries ILLUSTRATION: PARTHA PRATIM SHARMA

and arrive with a choice of scrumptious cookies. Jacob asks for black coffee and tells us that the first thing he drinks in the morning is black coffee with ghee, as it raises blood ketone levels and lowers insulin level. "Black coffee keeps me alert," he says, adding that he also drinks two to three glasses of fresh lime soda with green chilli every day. "Green chillis have antioxidant properties," he says.

Jacob sure knows all about food properties, being in the spice extraction business, so we don't argue with him.

Synthite Industries — founded by his father, CV Jacob, in 1970 — is the world's largest producer and exporter of spice extracts, oleoresins, and essential oils, supplying flavour components to the likes of Nestle, Unilever and Pepsico, and has a commanding 35 per cent global market share. In four key crops — paprika, turmeric, pepper and capsicum — it has near 20 per cent market share.

But Jacob has his fingers in many pies, from realty (Riviera Retreat, Spice Villas) to

nutraceuticals. His father was one of the first investors in CIAL, which operates Kochi airport, and Jacob today occupies a director's post, taking a keen interest in aviation.

After taking over the reins at Synthite, which was primarily B2B, he led the group into several downstream B2C expansions, including artisanal chocolate brand Paul & Mike, which is served to us along with our coffee and has some unique flavours like Sichuan pepper and orange peel, and Balkan rose. We learn that the brand is named after two legendary Latin American cocoa farmers. Jacob launched NatXtra, a nutraceutical B2C, in 2020. Synthite also owns the consumer spice brand Kitchen Treasures.

Consolidated, the group recently hit \$500 million (about ₹4,790 crore) in revenue and made headlines as Jacob projected a revenue target of \$1 billion by 2030.

How will he do it in such a short time, we ask him. "In the food industry we still have 60 per cent more headroom. People want different things

every day... different flavours and different taste products are coming up," he says.

"I often go to the shops and see what new products have come in. I buy a couple of products, especially supplements, to figure out which is the most popular ingredient today," he says.

The big orders for natural essences include vetiver oil, ginger oil and garlic oil, he says. "The perfume industry is going to change altogether because consumers are rejecting synthetic aromas, and the industry is moving more and more into natural scents, which gives us a lot of headroom," he adds.

The US is curbing the use of synthetic colours and moving to natural colours. "So I got an order for 200 tonnes of paprika and 300 tonnes of curcumin within one year," he says.

In India, Synthite is watching with interest the growing focus of regulatory body FSSAI on the use of artificial flavours. "For us, the opportunity lies in supporting customers with high-quality, natural and compliant flavour and ingredient solutions that meet evolving regulatory requirements and consumer expectations," he says.

Paul & Mike is not too well known outside Kerala. Jacob admits he has to raise visibility for the B2C brands. "Our focus will be on increasing brand awareness, reaching more consumers and expanding into new markets. The level of investment will depend on the growth opportunities we see in each market," he says.

As our coffee cups run empty and the afternoon light fades over Vembanad lake, we realise that Jacob, with his restless energy and eye for changing consumer tastes, could well hit the \$1-billion mark — flavourfully!

CM
Y
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DATA BANK.

Microfinance lenders turn cautious even as loan size grows

The microfinance industry witnessed a 12 per cent year-on-year (yoy) contraction in total portfolio outstanding (POS) from ₹3,07,000 crore as at June-end 2025 to ₹2,69,274 crore as at June-end 2026, according to the latest 'Microfinance Pulse Report' released by Equifax and SIDBI.

Between March (POS ₹2,77,053 crore) and June (₹2,69,274 crore) this year, the sector recorded a 3 per cent quarter-over-quarter (qoq) contraction, suggesting that lenders are following a cautious path, according to the report.

Simultaneously, as at June-end 2026, year-on-year the number of active live borrowers and active loans declined 27 per cent (5.61 crore versus 7.69 crore) and 29 per cent (7.15 crore versus 10.10 crore), respectively.

The data reveals a shift in lending strategy from traditional small-ticket loans to higher-value disbursements, even as the segment for loans under ₹50,000 is rapidly shrinking, the report said.

The average ticket size (ATS) increased 11 per cent to ₹62,962 in the April-May-June (AMJ) 2026 period against ₹56,750 in AMJ 2025. The market share of high-value loans (above ₹75,000) surged from 28 per cent in AMJ 2025 to 41 per cent in AMJ 2026.

The continuous growth in ATS shows that lenders are focusing their capital on existing borrowers with established credit histories who can safely absorb larger loans.

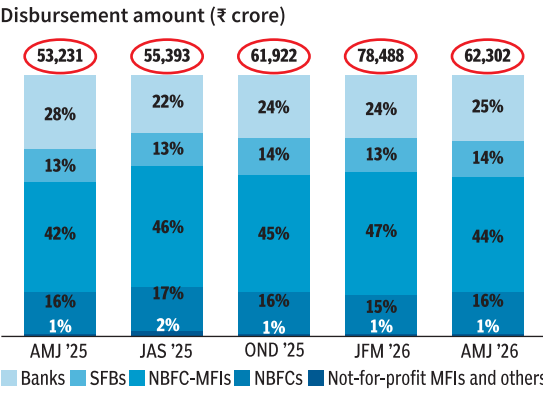
Despite the 21 per cent qoq drop, total disbursement value grew by 17 per cent in AMJ 2026 (₹62,302 crore) compared with AMJ 2025 (₹52,231 crore), confirming that market growth is primarily driven by larger ticket sizes rather than net new borrower acquisition.

The microfinance industry's 30-plus days past due (DPD) delinquency declined by 419 basis points to 1.89 per cent in June 2026 from 6.08 per cent in June 2025, while the 90-plus DPD delinquency fell by 259 basis points to 1.05 per cent from 3.64 per cent.

The geographical composition of microfinance lending is also undergoing a structural shift, with high-density markets in north India gaining more prominence, according to the report.

Bihar has emerged as the largest microfinance market, accounting for 17 per cent of industry portfolio outstanding at ₹44,572 crore, followed by Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu at 12 per cent each. Over the five-year period from June 2022 to 2026, Uttar Pradesh's portfolio grew 41 per cent, while Bihar's portfolio grew 24 per cent. Importantly, the top 10 states recorded a decline in 30-plus delinquency between June 2025 and 2026, with Odisha reporting the lowest delinquency at 1.25 per cent.

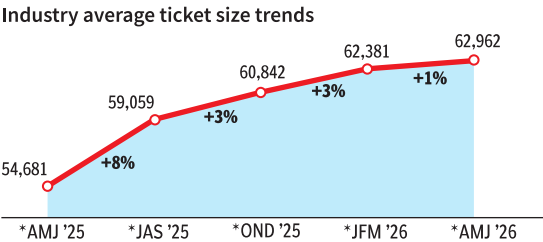
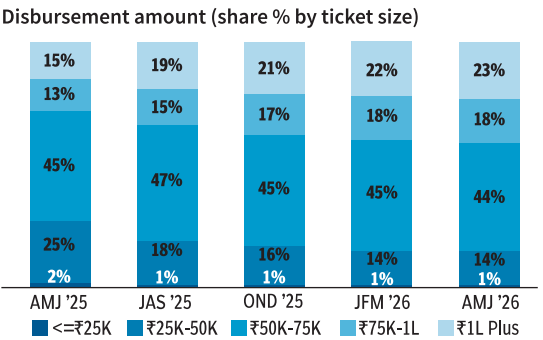
Healthy 17% YoY growth in disbursements reflects a sectoral resilience



Number of loans disbursed (in lakh)

Type	AMJ '25	JAS '25	OND '25	JFM '26	AMJ '26
Banks	30	21	26	30	25
SFBS	12	12	13	16	13
NBFC-MFIs	42	46	49	63	47
NBFCs	12	13	13	14	13
Not-for-profit MFIs and others	1	1	1	2	1
Total industry	97	93	102	125	99

Lenders are shifting away from entry-level loans (less than ₹50,000)



Microfinance industry snapshot

Microfinance Industry	June 2026	June 2025	% change
Active live borrowers ('000)	56,096	76,872	-27.02674576
Active loans ('000)	71,544	101064	-29.20921396
Portfolio (₹ crore)	269274	307000	-12.28859935
Disbursed amount (₹crore) AMJ*	62,302	58,140	7.158582731
Average ticket size (₹) - AMJ	62,962	56,750	10.94625551
30+ Delinquency (POS)	1.89%	6.08%	
30+ Delinquency (POS)	1.05%	3.64%	

Note: *AMJ - April-May-June; JAS - July-August-September; OND - October-November-December; JFM - January-February-March

Source: Equifax

FLOW CHART

Why GIFT City is an NRI magnet

DESI DRAW. From Mozambique to Mexico, wealthy non-resident Indians are heading to the international financial centre

Avinash Nair

From Mozambique and Mexico to the more established NRI markets such as the UK, the US and Dubai, a new set of wealthy Indians are streaming into the financial ecosystem of Gujarat International Finance Tec-City, or GIFT City, in Gandhinagar. Nearly 500 high net-worth individuals (HNIs) have used the foreign currency non-resident (bank) deposit, or FCNR(B), facility through the GIFT International Financial Services Centre (IFSC) for the first time, with several bringing in an estimated \$1-10 million. The development is significant for not just the size of the funds mobilised but also taking GIFT IFSC to geographies and customer segments that have so far remained outside its radar.

The new customer flow comes alongside a dramatic surge in FCNR(B) activity at the international financial centre. Twenty international banking units (IBUs) had sanctioned loans aggregating \$54.02 billion under the RBI's special swap facility by August 31, of which \$52.82 billion has been disbursed.

Sanctions had grown from \$28.6 billion on August 14 to \$37.26 billion on August 21, ahead of the surge by the month-end, as banks and overseas customers moved to take advantage of the facility ahead of the early closure of the deposit window.

The bigger question now is whether these customers will stay beyond the life of the RBI facility. In an exclusive interaction with *businessline*, K Rajaraman, Chairman of the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) — the unified regulator in GIFT City — said many of the NRIs who came through the FCNR (B) window were first-time customers of GIFT IFSC and were earlier unaware of the opportunities available there.

With banks now launching wealth management products at the IFSC, he expects some of these HNIs to return with larger investments and use the wider GIFT IFSC ecosystem for asset management — potentially turning what began as a temporary funding window into a longer-term customer relationship.

Edited excerpts:

Given that IBUs provided leverage of \$52.82 billion to NRIs under the special FCNR(B) deposit facility, do you see this opening up new opportunities for investment-related services for entities within GIFT IFSC?



MOBILISING STRENGTH. K Rajaraman, Chairman, International Financial Services Centres Authority, the unified regulator in (right) GIFT City

A lot of the customers who have used the leverage facility via IBUs are first-time customers in GIFT IFSC. Some of them were not even aware of the opportunities available in GIFT IFSC. Mostly these FCNR(B) customers are from the UK, USA and Dubai. Some of them have come from countries like Mozambique and Mexico. Some of the richest NRIs of those countries are coming for the first time. We have thus made a breakthrough into a few new geographies. Normally we are looking at big geographies where at least 50,000 NRIs are living. But there are centres that have fewer NRIs but they fall in the HNI category.

So the significance is not necessarily in the number of NRIs in a country but their wealth profile?

Exactly. There are markets where the overall Indian diaspora may be relatively small, but there can still be a significant HNI population. The FCNR (B) facility has helped us reach some of these customers for the first time.

How large is this new customer segment?

The number of individual bank depositors in IBUs in GIFT City will be around 33,000. This new retail customer segment which availed itself of the FCNR leverage from GIFT IFSC would be 500-odd. These HNIs are in the higher bracket and many of them would have brought in between \$1 million and \$10 million. Some of these HNIs are experiencing GIFT City for the first time. We expect many of them to come back with bigger investments and use the ecosystem for their asset management requirements.

The special FCNR(B) scheme was for a limited period. Will the NRIs who used the leverage from



IBUs to place fresh FCNR(B) deposits present an opportunity for recurring business?

Now that they know about the opportunities available here, and with the wealth management products launched by many IBUs, this looks like the beginning of a long relationship between GIFT IFSC and these customers. The special FCNR (B) leverage has, therefore, brought in customers who can potentially use other parts of the GIFT IFSC ecosystem.

How significant was the overall FCNR(B) deposit mobilisation?

As of August 31, the IBUs had sanctioned \$54.02 billion under the RBI's special swap facility, of which approximately \$52.82 billion had been disbursed. Public sector banks accounted for 37.76 per cent of the FCNR(B) deposit-linked leverage; private sector banks 41.59 per cent; and foreign banks 20.65 per cent. The top five IBUs — HSBC Bank, ICICI Bank, Bank of Baroda, SBI and Canara Bank — collectively accounted for 63.85 per cent of the FCNR(B) deposit-linked loans disbursed.

Sanctions jumped by \$25.4 billion between August 14 and August 31, taking the total to \$54.02 billion. What triggered this sharp acceleration in the final weeks of the FCNR(B) window?

The RBI, in view of the strong demand for placing FCNR(B) deposits, announced on August 14 that the special USD-INR forex swap facility would be available only for FCNR(B) deposits mobilised up to August 31, advancing the deadline from the original September 30. With the deadline brought forward by a month, it created a clear deadline effect. NRIs, in-

stitutional offshore funds and bank treasury desks across jurisdictions moved to lock in the concessional swap rates and attractive yields available under the facility before the window closed.

The Ministry of Finance also advised the chiefs of public sector banks to actively leverage the institutional infrastructure available at GIFT IFSC. Consequently, banks scaled up their offshore processing and operational capacities across their respective IBUs to handle and accommodate the increased volumes generated by the facility. This combination of strong underlying demand, shortened window, and banks ramping up their operational capacity resulted in a sharp acceleration in sanctions during the second half of August.

Was the FCNR surge largely concentrated in a handful of IBUs?

The participation was broad-based. Although the top five IBUs accounted for 63.85 per cent of the total loans disbursed, almost all the IBUs that are offering retail products participated in this. The participation of public-sector, private-sector and foreign banks demonstrates the depth and capability of the banking ecosystem at GIFT IFSC.

How does FCNR fit into the broader growth of banking activity at GIFT IFSC?

As of August 31 this year, the IBUs had cumulative assets of about \$193 billion, compared with \$93.5 billion in August 2025. The biggest growth is coming from ECBs (external commercial borrowings) and trade finance. It is basically a corporate market. But now, FCNR has brought in the retail segment, where IBUs have leveraged \$52.82 billion through the facility. This cre-

ates a new dimension for the ecosystem because these customers can potentially move beyond deposits into wealth management and other financial services.

So, could the real legacy of the FCNR facility be the customers it has brought to GIFT IFSC, rather than the deposits themselves?

These customers came to GIFT IFSC for the loans under the FCNR leverage facility... The FCNR window was a specific facility, but the relationships created through it can continue.

The fact that customers from traditional markets such as the UK, the US and Dubai have come in alongside HNIs from less obvious markets such as Mozambique and Mexico shows that the potential customer base for GIFT IFSC may be wider than previously assumed.

You recently travelled to Italy and France with some banks to meet alternative investment funds and financial services stakeholders. What interest are you seeing from Italian financial institutions, particularly as India-Italy trade expands?

Indo-Italian trade is now picking up. It is at roughly \$13 billion, and we are looking to double it by 2029. That means a lot of effort has to be put in for providing trade finance and ensuring greater import-export activity. For that, our banking system is required. We are looking forward to Italian banks coming to GIFT City. If you look at Italian companies in India, there are 1,053 of them, but only one bank has a representative office in Delhi. A few banks in Italy appeared to be interested in coming to India.

Insurance is protection, financial resilience

As the general insurance market remains under-penetrated, it is time to change the narrative around risk management



KG KRISHNAMOORTHY RAO

The recent glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF) in Nepal is a stark reminder that climate change is real. It is also a reminder why insurance matters for everyone. After all, it is one of the few financial tools that can help build resilience by transferring a part of the risk and enabling faster recovery after catastrophic events.

And yet, for the past several years, India's general insurance market has remained heavily under-penetrated, at roughly 1 per cent of GDP as against the global average of over 4 per cent. There is a need for not just more insurance policies but also a fundamental shift in how people view insurance.

The country's growth story is hard to ignore. The economy reached sixth globally with \$3.92 trillion GDP in 2025-26. We are building across sectors, from information technology, healthcare, manufacturing and financial services to infrastructure, e-commerce and renewable energy. Driven by rising incomes, urbanisation and improved access to education and technology, the middle

class too is growing. The assets and wealth we create as we grow individually, and as a nation, need to be protected, especially as risks continue to rise. And yet, insurance remains misunderstood or unknown.

THE BIG GAP

When I joined the insurance industry about 38 years ago, I had hardly heard about any insurance product other than life insurance, and that too since a relative worked in LIC. Awareness on insurance is still very low among the public, though after the Covid-19 pandemic there has been some growth in interest in health insurance. However, insurance protection for homes, other assets, and risks is largely overlooked. Even when they do recognise the risks, most people tend to insure what is mandatory rather than what is financially important.

Motor insurance is a case in point. It is often purchased because the law requires it, rather than because vehicle owners understand the financial implications of an accident. Similarly, many homeowners think "nothing will happen to my home", and do not explore property insurance.

This is why the next phase of insurance growth will require the industry to sell not just policies but also an understanding of risk.



ISTOCK

There have been some awareness initiatives from the insurance regulator and the industry. However, disasters such as the most recent one in Nepal, the Assam floods this year, or the 2024 Wayanad landslide have shown us that Nat-Cat (natural catastrophe) events can cause enormous damage to property and lives within minutes. And in a world with intensifying climate risks, safeguarding your assets is the only logical thing to do.

VALUE OF INSURANCE

One of the biggest barriers to buying insurance is its perception as an expense. Many people reason that if the event against which they are insured does not happen, then they do not get anything back. This is

making early in their life.

There is a lot to learn from disaster management. Governments may step in after a disaster to rebuild homes and restore livelihoods. But beyond that, the responsibility for maintaining and protecting those assets returns to the individual. Insurance can help households absorb future shocks without having to start over.

India's endeavour to ensure 'insurance for all' goes beyond increasing the number of policies or improving insurance penetration. The ultimate goal should be a financially resilient India — one where individuals, families and businesses are better equipped to absorb shocks and recover from them.

For vulnerable sections of society, government support is needed to ensure protection is not limited to those who can afford it. However, the industry, regulators, and consumers have an equally important role to play.

The country has spent the past 25 years expanding its insurance industry. The next 25 should be about expanding the idea of protection itself. From product awareness to risk awareness. From selling policies to building financial literacy. From insurance penetration to meaningful protection.

The writer is the Managing Director and CEO of General Central Insurance

QUICKLY.

Iran not to soften demand after US rejects truce bid



Iran said it's awaiting a definitive US response to a seven-day proposal for reopening the Strait of Hormuz but won't soften its conditions. The country is aware of Trump voicing his rejection though has yet to receive anything from mediators, Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi was cited as saying. Only a "negotiated solution" can resolve the impasse over the bottleneck, he added. "They made a proposal but I rejected it," Trump said Saturday, referring to Iran. "They want to make a deal... because they're losing so badly," BLOOMBERG

Titan bets on premium watches as automatic biz scales 5x

TIME ON ITS SIDE. Despite competition from Swiss, Japanese brands, opportunity extends beyond metros in India, says watches division head Kuruvilla Markose

bl.interview

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Titan is betting that India's appetite for mechanical watches has further room to run. Its automatic-watch business expected to reach ₹350-400 crore this fiscal, up from ₹265 crore last year. The business has grown nearly five-fold from ₹50 crore in FY23, as younger and increasingly discerning consumers show greater willingness to trade up. Kuruvilla Markose, CEO of Titan's Watches Division, says the premiumisation opportunity extends well beyond metros, with about 70 per cent of consumption coming from breakout towns and tier-1 and -2

markets. Edited excerpts:

Titan's portfolio is still heavily weighted towards watches below ₹25,000. How do you see that changing?

The shift towards ₹25,000-plus is already visible. The segment is growing at around 35 per cent, compared with about 15 per cent for the sub-₹25,000 segment. For Titan, the above ₹25,000 segment grew nearly 50 per cent in FY27, compared with around 20-22 per cent for the below ₹25,000 segment.

Over the next three to five years, we expect ₹25,000-plus to become an increasingly important part of our portfolio. We see an opportunity to grow this segment by around 50-60 per cent over the next two years. Within this, aspirational lux-

Over the next 12-24 months, our focus will be on building a meaningful pipeline of mechanical products rather than simply chasing a large number of launches

KURUVILLA MARKOSE
CEO, Watches Division



in the ₹50,000-1 lakh range, or further up the luxury spectrum?

The opportunity is much larger than building a ₹50,000-1 lakh mechanical business. We are looking at a long mechanical-watch making journey across price points and levels of capability.

How far can Titan realistically climb the mechanical-watch ladder? Is the opportunity primarily

ury could grow around 40 per cent, while the higher luxury segment could grow around 100 per cent.

Indigenous secure radios for IAF fighter jets in final phase; expected to be completed by year-end

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Indian Air Force (IAF) can expect the development of an indigenous Software Defined Radio (SDR) — the next generation communication system conceived by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) — to complete by the end of this year.

The system offers secured wireless communication network across the IAF's fighter aircrafts and ground stations for operations with enhanced security protocols.

SEAMLESS FLOW

So far, the Indian Navy had installed the DRDO-developed "SDR Tactical" for ship-to-ship, ship-to-shore and ship-to-air voice, video and data communication for network centric operations,



BETTER SYSTEM. Once the SDR goes into production, it will offer an option to the Indian Air Force to switch over to the indigenous communication system

supporting simultaneous operation of all the four channels.

Similarly, the Indian Army is also in the process of integrating the indigenous "SDR MANPAC" across its all arms and units to equip them with high data rates and Mobile Ad hoc Network (MANET) capabilities, strengthening its operational readiness.

Once the SDR goes into

production, it will offer an option to the IAF to switch over to the indigenous communication system. The IAF has installed Israeli's B-Net system, produced by Rafael Advanced Defence Systems, on its fighter jets after inking a deal in 2017.

"We are still working to develop an SDR dedicated to the IAF. We expect to prove some waveform by the end of

this year," BK Das, Director General at DRDO's Bengaluru-based Electronic Communication Systems cluster, told *businessline*. SDRs for Navy and Army have already been handed over to them, he added.

As per the SDR technology, a waveform is defined, generated, and shaped entirely through software and programmable logic rather than through fixed, dedicated hardware circuits that existed in old communication systems.

The state-owned BEL is DRDO's manufacturing partner for the different versions of SDRs developed for the Army and the Navy, with the domestic industry contributing to the supply chain.

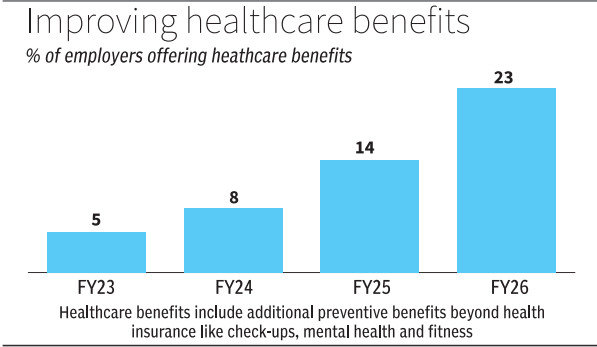
Once the complete SDR communication network architecture is established across the tri-services, the secured flow of voice, video

and data among men and machines will become seamless — a move in sync with the proposed theatreisation of command the government is trying to push to meet modern warfare demands, Das said.

THERE'S MORE

The DRDO DG also stated that one of his labs — Defence Electronics Applications Laboratory (DEAL) which is the central hub for the design and development of SDR systems — is developing the next version of Indian Radio Software Architecture (IRSA) standard to enable interoperability in military communication. The IRSA is a comprehensive software specification for SDR, defining standardised interfaces, APIs, execution environments, and waveform portability mechanisms.

Firms offering healthcare benefits see 13% drop in chronic claims, says report



Sindhu Hariharan
Rohan Das
Chennai

India Inc is increasingly supplementing basic insurance coverage for employees with wider benefits such as preventive check-ups, tele-health, gym memberships and mental health services, and this is facilitating better health and well-being outcomes for their employees, showed a new research.

Companies that have invested in healthcare benefits have seen nearly a 13 per cent reduction in incidence of chronic claims, per an analysis by digital-first insurance platform Plum. The lower claim incidence can translate to premium savings of as much as ₹480 per employee during renewal of insurance plans, it added.

THE RIGHT STEPS

Plum's data suggests that 23 per cent of analysed companies in FY26 combine insurance with preventive healthcare, up from 14 per cent last year and 5 per cent in FY23.

Indian organisations are beginning to take the right steps towards investment in the health and financial protection of their employees, said Abhishek Poddar, CEO, Plum.

"What used to be the top quartile of benefits in 2024 has now become the median

of benefits. That is the signal that these investments have gone from perceived surplus to bare minimum with organisations."

Plum's analysis showed that companies offering sum insured over ₹5 lakh has increased 53 per cent while those offering a maternity limit above ₹75,000 has increased 155 per cent. Companies adding term life and personal accidents have increased 179 per cent.

MORE BENEFITS

Mental health-related benefits and services are offered by over a third of the companies surveyed overall. This is at 52 per cent for MNCs, 39 per cent for funded start-ups and 11 per cent for local Indian firms.

The analysis also showed that, for the average company, the number of healthcare benefits offered in addition to insurance has increased from just one in FY23 to three in FY26.

The degree of growth varies depending on the size and type of the company. International companies do far better than their Indian peers when it comes to offering holistic benefits, said Shreyas Achar, CMO, Plum. Within Indian companies, a similar gulf exists between start-ups with venture-capital backing and local bootstrapped businesses.

XED takes private route as GIFT City IPO dream awaits lift-off

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Global executive education provider XED Executive Development, which withdrew its proposed IPO from GIFT City's International Financial Services Centre (IFSC) in March, is pursuing a \$10 million private placement, while keeping open the option of a future listing.

XED Promoter and Managing Director John Kallelil said the company no longer depends on an IPO to raise capital and has already received investor commitments. "Our objective in GIFT City was to raise funds. There are various ways of doing that, and we are currently

in the market to raise \$10 million. We have already received a few commitments and are in the middle of a transaction," Kallelil told *businessline* from New York.

WHEN TIME IS RIGHT

XED remains committed to the GIFT City ecosystem and could revisit listing plans when market conditions are more favourable, he said. "We continue to value the support of GIFT City and, when the time is right, we will certainly look at coming back. We maintain all governance standards and approvals required for a public listing, so the conversation continues."

XED was set to become the first company to use

IN THE WORKS

While the regulatory framework for direct overseas listings is in place, the investor ecosystem at GIFT City, needed to support regular equity issuances, is still evolving



GIFT IFSC's direct-listing framework through a proposed listing on NSE International Exchange (NSE IX) and India International Exchange (India INX). However, its withdrawal highlights a broader challenge facing GIFT IFSC.

While the regulatory

creating an alternative route for Indian companies to access foreign-currency capital.

Haigreve Khaitan, Managing Partner at Khaitan & Co, said market depth and liquidity will take time to develop. "Investors need confidence that listed stocks will have adequate trading volumes and liquidity. Building that ecosystem takes time, although momentum can accelerate quickly once it starts."

The success of India's domestic markets has also reduced the urgency for companies to list overseas, especially after reforms enabled start-ups to go public without a profit track record, he added.

IFSCA Chairman K Rajaraman said the IFSC route is intended to complement, not replace, domestic exchanges. While listings on the NSE and BSE provide access to rupee funding and domestic investors, GIFT IFSC offers companies access to global investors and foreign-currency capital.

The IFSC also provides dollar-denominated trading and tax exemptions for overseas investors. Regulators are exploring further measures, including a framework for listings without a public offer, and expect foreign companies to add momentum to the market, with at least one US-based company already filing for an IFSC listing.

Despite high search interest, India lags behind the West in AI adoption curve

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai



India ranks in the "low" category of the AI adoption curve despite indicating a high search interest in the technology, according to a recent study based on Google AI usage data.

Conversational AI usage per capita has a strong concentration of demand within traditional advanced economies, the study said.

THE GAP

Globally, per capita AI usage closely mirrors national wealth, with a 1 per cent increase in GDP per capita associated with a 0.9 per cent increase in usage. This means the "lowest-adopting quintile" of countries accounts for only 2 per cent of AI conversations. Despite this, the highest share of local search queries come from emerging economies in South Asia.

India sits at the extreme ends of both these trends.

Even with its large population and contributions to the global STEM graduate population, India was categorised in the "low" tier of the adoption curve with sub-Saharan Africa, and parts of Central and South Asia ranking in the "very low" category. It was largely attributed to infrastructure bottlenecks and physical connectivity limitations. But India, along with Bangladesh, Nepal and other Southeast Asian and East African countries showed exceptionally high public curi-

osity and interest in active research into AI topics relative to overall search activity, signalling strong grassroots interest in the technology's capabilities.

So, there is a notable "interest-adoption gap" across different development tiers.

ON THE OTHER HAND...

"In advanced economies, conversational AI may have already transitioned from a novel subject of active search query exploration into an embedded, background utility in daily workflows. Conversely, in many emerging markets, massive interest and digital curiosity have yet to fully translate into high levels of per capita conversational usage," said the paper.

Part of this was attributed to structural tokenisation biases, where non-Western text requires more tokens per word, inadvertently driving up both API expenses and latency for non-European languages.

PB Health's hospital expansion plans on track: Group CEO Yashish Dahiya

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

PB Health is a separate venture and will see no change in its hospital expansion plans, said Yashish Dahiya, Chairman and Group CEO of PB Fintech Ltd, the parent company of Policybazaar.

NO IMPACT

Responding to whether a possible impact on its insurance business from a recently proposed policy change would cast a shadow on its healthcare investment plans, Dahiya said PB Health is a totally separate venture with its own team and execution. "So no, that doesn't get impacted by what goes on at the Policybazaar end... If there are challenges at the Policybazaar end, this part actually becomes even more important," he said, indicating that their investment plans for about 150 hospitals in five years, were on track.



Yashish Dahiya, Chairman and Group CEO, PB Fintech Ltd

A recent IRDAI consultation paper had proposed changes in insurance distribution commissions among other things, adversely impacting PB Fintech's stock-price last week.

With PB Health being the healthcare venture from the group, concerns also emerge of a possible slowdown of its expansion plans. Dahiya, however, clarified, "this investment comes from external investors and the Policybazaar balance sheet, and the balance sheet is intact

and there are no challenges there." The plan is for 20-30 new hospitals, and the rest through partnerships or franchise operations, he said.

PB Health presently has multi-speciality hospitals in Noida and Gurugram. With a plan for 200-bed hospitals, the target is for four hospitals by March, and another six in the next year, followed by a rapid expansion, he said.

A CONFLICT?

While groups like Narayana Health have gone from hospitals to health insurance, PB Health is doing the opposite. Industry insiders, however, raise concerns on a possible conflict of interest when the same group is present on both sides.

Dahiya defends the strategy. "These are two separate companies. There is no insurance specialist at PB Health. All [that] the doctors are informed is that you have no targets..." he said.